

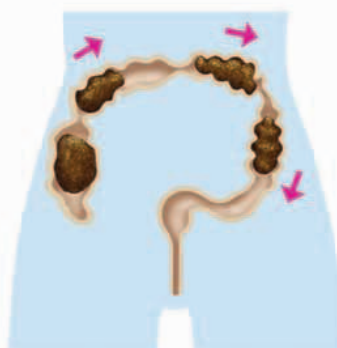
MOVING THINGS ALONG

As indigestible waste food is mixed and formed into feces, it is propelled along the colon by three types of movements (below). All are produced by contractions of the circular muscles and the three bands of muscle

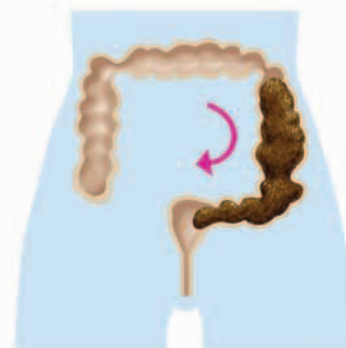
that run the length of the colon. Movement of material along the colon is slower than in other parts of the digestive system. This gives more time for as much water as possible to be absorbed from the waste.



▲ **SEGMENTATION** Every 30 minutes, the muscles contract to pinch waste into pellets that are mixed but not moved.



▲ **PERISTALSIS** Alternating waves of muscular contraction and relaxation push the pellets towards the rectum.



▲ **MASS MOVEMENTS** Three times a day, powerful contractions force feces from the descending colon into the rectum.

The descending colon travels down the left side of the abdomen.

Pouches in the colon are called haustra.

Feces are pushed downward by contractions of the rectum wall

Bladder

Anal canal links rectum to anus

Anus

WOW!

Always wash your hands after going to the bathroom. Feces are 50 percent bacteria, and some are harmful.

◀ WASTE DISPOSAL

Contractions of the colon push feces into the normally empty rectum. This stretches the rectum wall, triggering an urge to go to the bathroom. Two powerful sphincter muscles, which keep the anus closed, relax. The rectum wall contracts and pushes the feces out through the open anus.

Anal sphincter muscles relax to allow feces to pass through

WHY THE APPENDIX?

The thin, dead-end tube called the appendix was once thought to have no function at all in humans. Scientists now believe that it plays a part in our body's defenses, forming part of the immune system. It also stores friendly bacteria to replace those in the colon, in case they're flushed out during an attack of diarrhea (runny feces).



▲ X-RAY OF THE APPENDIX

This colored X-ray image shows the slender, fingerlike appendix located near to where the small intestine (right) joins the large intestine (left).